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Professional or interactive: CEOs' image strategies in the microblogging context

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ABSTRACT

Microblogging platforms are gaining popularity among corporations and their top management in recent years. Although microblogging services like Twitter and Sina Weibo are now prevalently used for managing CEOs' images and public relations, few studies have examined the effects of these practices on the loyalty of target audiences. This study examined the effect of CEO image strategy on follower loyalty in the microblogging context. Based on the self-presentation theory, four types of CEO image strategies were identified, namely the Expert, Friend, Textbook, and Daybook strategies. These categories were identified based on the levels of interactivity and professionalism of the CEOs on their microblogs. An online survey was used to collect data from microblog users, that is, the CEOs' followers. The results showed that CEO image strategy influences follower loyalty in the microblogging context and that Chinese microblog users are fondest of CEOs who present themselves as experts rather than as friends (H1). The results also showed that usage orientation moderates the effect of CEO image on follower loyalty (H2) and that goal orientation positively influences CEOs with a highly professional image.

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1. Introduction

From a business perspective, social media has significantly changed the way companies communicate with their consumers. In contrast to mass media, social media allows consumers to voice their opinions and share information and experiences with companies to fellow consumers. Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) defined social media as being "a group of Internet-based applications that build on the ideological and technological foundations of Web 2.0 and that allow the creation and exchange of User Generated Content" (p. 61). Social media in general and microblogs in particular provide means to interact with customers (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2011). Twitter, the global microblogging pioneer, was originally developed for mobile phones, designed to let people post short, 140-character text updates or 'tweets' to a network of others. Tweets could be spread further when participants repost tweets through their accounts introducing content to new audiences (Marwick & boyd, 2011). Microblogging services have gained popularity in recent years. The number of active users for Twitter was 255 million as of March 31, 2014 (Twitter, 2014). The advances in social media are offering an unprecedentedly easy, convenient, and flexible way for corporate leaders to manage their public relations and personal images. The CEO's image and the corporation's reputation both play major roles in determining a company's success in building relationships with diverse stakeholders (Jin & Yeo, 2011). Some 54 percent of top executives surveyed by Yankelovich Partners, a marketing services consultancy, "believed that at least half of a company's corporate reputation could be attributed to the public image of its CEO" (Business Editors., 2001).

For top-level executives, social media can provide opportunities to form new relationships as well as strengthen existing relationships with customers, investors, employees, and the public (Karaduman, 2013). According to a survey of employees by social media branding firm BRAND fog (2014), the majority of US and UK respondents believe that CEO engagement on social media helps to communicate company values and shapes a company's brand reputation. Another study on the online activities of CEOs from 50 of the world's largest companies demonstrated that in 2012, 66% were deemed a "social CEO" in that they appeared in videos on the company's YouTube channel or had a public and verifiable profile on Facebook and Twitter; this figure is nearly double that in 2010 (Weber Shandwick., 2013).

China is the most active microblogging market in the world. According to the China Internet Network Information Center (2014), the administrative agency responsible for Internet affairs under the Ministry of Information Industry, there were 281 million users of microblogging services in China by the end of 2013, many of whom follow popular business leaders in the country. For

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example, Kai-Fu Lee, the CEO of Innovation Works and former president of Google China, and Yun Ma, the CEO of the Alibaba Group, are some of the well-known business leaders on the Chinese version of Twitter 'Sina Weibo', each with over 50 million and 15 million followers, respectively, as of April 30, 2014.

Although microblogging platforms like Twitter and Sina Weibo are now prevalently used for managing CEOs' images and public relations, few studies have examined the effects of these practices on the loyalty of target audiences. Many companies are experimenting with microblogging platforms, but few studies provide guidance on the best microblogging practices for corporations (Burton & Soboleva, 2011). In this study, we explored the image strategy for CEOs that has a more significant and positive effect on follower loyalty in the context of a CEO's microblog. Based on the self-presentation theory, we classified image strategies of CEOs communicating through microblogging platforms according to their level of professionalism and interactivity with their followers. The four CEO image strategy categories are Expert, Friend, Textbook, and Daybook. Usage orientation was used as a moderator to examine the effects of those strategies on follower loyalty. Using online survey, the research examined the different effects of the four categories of CEO image strategies on follower loyalty.

2. Theory and hypotheses development

Self-presentation "consists of behaviors designed to make a desired impression on others" (Vohs, Baumeister, & Ciarocco, 2005, p. 633). A person can present multiple facets of his or her personality at different occasions rather than a simple unified self (James, 1950). On microblogging platforms, CEOs communicate to both internal and external stakeholders and are motivated to present different versions of themselves to accommodate their target audiences. For instance, CEOs could present themselves as experts owing to their rich knowledge in an industry or a technological field, or as mentors to youth owing to their desirable social experience.

2.1. Professionalism

Jameson (2014) defined professional communication as "that which arises from a person's work, vocation, or organizational roles, whereas personal communication arises from other roles and context." (p. 11). By taking advantage of the convenient interactions with followers on microblogging platforms, CEOs could narrow the psychological distance that usually exists between them and customers, enhance their reputation, and better present themselves. However, social media demands "quick, unscripted updates that can quickly go viral—poses risks for top managers and the companies they represent, in the form of lawsuits, leaked trade secrets or angered customers" (Kwoh & Korn, 2012). The first rule of microblogging is to focus on messages that are relevant for the target group (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2011). Online personal branding requires that information be accessible to others, which in turn puts people at risk in terms of misdirected and insufficient branding (Labrecque, Markos, & Milne, 2011). Traditionally, companies discourage employees from discussing business-related information outside the workplace. According to Jameson (2014) work-related communication can be shared with a wide range of audiences, however communicators should carefully determine the risk–benefit ratio of doing so. Therefore, CEOs have to establish rules for their microblogging practices and manage the boundaries between what should be public and private, professional and personal.

2.2. Interactivity

Social media is structured first and foremost to facilitate sharing and dialogue with other members. Goffman (1959) pointed out that impression management is embedded in social interactivity. Interactivity in this context could be defined as the extent to which a CEO's microblogging communication represents a two-way conversation (Lee & Shin, 2012). The two major advantages of microblogging platforms are one-to-many broadcasting and one-to-one interactivity. Unlike in other social media platforms (e.g., Facebook), following a microblog usually does not require permission or any reciprocal communication before making a connection. Microblogging platforms usually offer interactivity tools such as hashtags, URL links, mentions, replies, and forwards. A CEO may well decide to be proactive and initiate conversations and/or be reactive, typically responding to followers' posts and discussions.

Thus, based on the content of a CEO's communication (professional vs. personal) and social media's most prominent trait (interactivity), we developed a typology matrix for CEOs' image strategies in the microblogging context, as illustrated in Fig. 1.

We classified CEO image strategies into four types, which are described below:

2.2.1. Expert

The content of the messages posted by both the CEOs and their followers are highly related to the CEOs' industry, such as technological trends in the related fields, market forecasts, and new product development. CEOs classified as experts are highly active in addressing questions, responding to followers' suggestions or comments, and forwarding business-related messages.

2.2.2. Friend

While the CEOs classified as friends are highly interactive with their followers, the content of their messages are less related to their industries. Rather, the message topics cover diverse aspects of life, such as popular social issues, life philosophies, and hobbies, like sports.

2.2.3. Textbook

The content of the messages of CEOs classified as textbook are professional like those of Expert CEOs, but the interactions between the CEOs and their followers are lower. The CEOs hardly initiate discussions with or respond to followers.

2.2.4. Daybook

The content of the messages of CEOs classified as daybook neither indicate professionalism nor interactivity. The content of the messages appear like the CEOs' routine activities in their daybook, devoid of emotion or interest in their followers' responses.

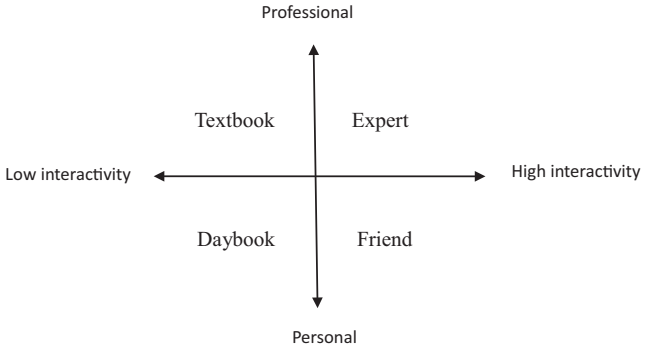


Fig. 1. Image strategy of CEOs on their microblogs.

2.3. Uses and gratification theory

The uses and gratifications theory provides one of the most relevant perspectives to explain psychological and behavioral dimensions involving computer-mediated communication (Lin, 1996; Ruggiero, 2000). Xu, Ryan, Prybutok, and Wen (2012) found that user utilitarian (rational and goal-oriented) gratifications of immediate access and coordination, hedonic (pleasure-oriented) gratifications of affection and leisure, and virtual social presence (social-oriented) are positive predictors of social network usage. Witkemper, Lim, and Waldburger (2012) examined motives (and constraints) that influence sports-related Twitter usage in relation to following athletes and found that utilitarian gratification (information) and hedonic gratification (entertainment, passing time, and enthusiasm) are major motives. Hughes, Rowe, Batey, and Lee (2012) pointed out that informational use of microblogging is goal-oriented and that followers use it (Twitter, in their study) for utilitarian value and cognitive stimulation. Whiting and Williams (2013) found that the main uses and gratifications for social media are first, social interactions, second, information seeking, and third, passing time.

In this study, we assumed that unlike fans of sport stars, followers of CEOs are mainly driven by goal-oriented and social-oriented gratifications rather than by pleasure-oriented gratification. These followers' usage behaviors (listen, follow, forward, and reply to CEOs' messages) typically aim at getting useful business-related information. Such followers take advantage of social media to interact with successful business leaders whom they may not otherwise be able to meet in person. Users' gratification from social media positively affects their attitude and media loyalty (Currás-Pérez, Ruiz-Mafé, & Sanz-Blas, 2013). According to Chen (2011), "People can select from many media, so if they pick Twitter and stick with it, Twitter must be meeting needs in some way" (p. 757). This discussion led us to develop the hypotheses below:

H1. CEO image strategy on microblogging platforms influences follower loyalty.

H2. Usage orientation moderates the effect of image strategy on follower loyalty. (H2a) Goal-oriented followers are more loyal to a highly professional image (Expert and Textbook CEOs) than social-oriented followers are, and (H2b) social-oriented followers are more loyal to a highly interactive image (Expert and Friend CEOs) than goal-oriented followers.

3. Methodology

3.1. Procedure

We conducted an online survey through a commercial survey service platform. The participants were recruited mainly through three channels: sending invitations (with a hyperlink to the questionnaire webpage) to interested microblog users on two leading microblog services, Sina microblog and the Tencent microblog; emailing invitations to registered alumni who have agreed to participate in academic surveys; and directing random users to the survey through an online search engine when they searched for words related to microblogs. The data were collected over four weeks in October of 2011, and 235 people participated.

The first part of the survey asked two questions to filter the respondents. The first question asked respondents if they have registered an account on any microblogging service platform in the past six months, and the second asked if they have followed three or more corporate leaders or CEOs in the past six months. Only those who responded yes to both questions were directed to proceed with the rest of the survey. The respondents were then asked to name three CEOs whose microblogs they followed. If a respondent failed to provide three names, he or she was instructed not to proceed with the survey. Those who were able to name three CEOs were asked to respond to the second part.

The second part of the survey measured the degree of interactivity and professionalism of the CEO as conveyed in his or her microblog. Considering that a CEO may change his or her strategy by adjusting the level of interactivity and/or professionalism in the content of his or her messages, we limited the evaluation to within the past three months. To increase the validity of the measure, we allowed the participants to access and review the content of the identified CEOs' microblogs at anytime during the survey. Loyalty was measured immediately after the measures for professionalism and interactivity were completed.

The third part of the survey measured usage orientation. The respondents were not allowed to go back to the first and second parts of the survey to prevent them from speculating on the purpose of the survey. The final part of the survey collected the demographic data of the respondents.

3.2. Measures

3.2.1. Interactivity

A set of items measuring human-to-human interactive behavior derived from prior online research (Yin, 2002) were adopted and modified to suit the microblogging platform context. The respondents were asked to rate the CEOs' behaviors on a 5-point Likert-type scale ranging from "1 = totally disagree" to "5 = totally agree."

3.2.2. Professionalism

We developed a scale containing five statements to measure the level of professionalism of the CEOs, since we did not find an existing measure for this concept. Professionalism in this study refers to the degree that the content of the microblog are industry-related (e.g., technological advancement and new product development). A 5-point Likert-type scale was developed to measure professionalism, ranging from "1 = totally disagree" to "5 = totally agree."

3.2.3. Loyalty

We borrowed definitions and measures of brand loyalty to study followers' loyalties to CEOs' microblogs. Oliver (1999)defined brand loyalty as "a deeply held commitment to repurchase or repatronize a preferred product/service consistently in the future, thereby causing repetitive same-brand or same brand-set purchasing, despite situational influences and marketing efforts having the potential to cause switching behavior" (p.34). This definition emphasizes the two aspects of brand loyalty-behavioral and attitudinal (Aaker, 1991). We therefore defined the followers' loyalty to a CEO's microblog as the tendency to continue paying attention to the microblog in the future and to repetitively visit, listen, follow, post, forward, and reply to the content of the microblog. To measure loyalty, we combined and then modified the scales used by Gronholdt, Martensen, and Kristensen (2000) and Aaker (1991) into five items. A 5-point Likert scale was used here as well.

3.2.4. Usage orientation

We chose six items from the shopping orientation scale used by Yang (2009) and modified them slightly to fit the microblogging context of this study. Half of the items measure goal orientation and the other half measures social orientation.

4. Data analysis

4.1. Samples

There were 235 initial participants in the survey, and 35 did not pass the filtering in the first part of the survey, leaving 200 eligible participants with complete answers for our data analysis. The average age of the participants was 22 years; 52% were male; and 55% have at least an undergraduate degree. Some 60% of the respondents have used a microblogging service for more than six months. The participants identified a total of 11 CEOs, five of whom were followed by 70% of the participants.

4.2. Credibility

The Cronbach's alpha values were acceptable for all latent variables: interactivity ($\alpha = .83$), professionalism ($\alpha = .72$), usage orientation ($\alpha = .87$), and loyalty ($\alpha = .94$).

4.3. Classification of CEO's image strategies

We computed the means of interactivity and professionalism of the 11 CEOs who were identified. We then classified the CEOs into four categories according to their scores on the two dimensions (professionalism and interactivity). For example, if the scores on both dimensions were above the means, a CEO was classified as an expert.

4.4. Hypotheses test

A one-way ANOVA was carried out to examine the correlations between image strategies and follower loyalty. For the entire sample, the average follower loyalty for Expert, Textbook, Friend, and Daybook CEOs were 3.4124, 3.2911, 2.9367, and 2.9141, respectively, and the differences in follower loyalty among the four categories were significant. The results suggest that followers in China are fondest of CEOs who have a highly professional image and least fond of Daybook CEOs. Altogether, these findings support H1. The results of the one-way ANOVA are presented in Table 1.

A balanced ANOVA was performed to test H2. The results are presented in Table 2.

The results in Table 2 demonstrate that image strategy and usage orientation have a significant interaction effect on loyalty ($F = 4.561$, significance = .004). To test H2a and H2b, we conducted a paired t-test on the loyalty of two groups of followers (goal-oriented and social-oriented) to the four categories of CEO image strategies. The results are shown in Table 3.

The paired *t*-test results shown in Table 3 indicates that goal-oriented respondents have a significantly higher loyalty to both Expert and Textbook CEOs than social-oriented ones do, while social-oriented respondents have significantly higher loyalty to Friend CEOs than goal-oriented ones do. Thus, the results completely support H2a but only partially support H2b.

Table 1
Results of one-way ANOVA for H1.

Dependent variable: follower loyalty			Independent variable: image type		
	Sum of squares	*Df*	Mean square	*F*	Significance
Between groups	8.326	3	2.775	3.887	.010
Within groups	139.929	196	.714		
Total	148.255	199			

Table 2
Results of balanced ANOVA for H2.

Dependent variable: follower loyalty			Independent variable: image type, usage orientation		
Source	Sum of squares	*Df*	Mean square	*F*	Significance
Image	7.090	3	2.363	3.841	.011
Orientation	8.486	1	8.486	13.792	.000
Image * orientation	8.420	3	2.807	4.561	.004
Error	118.137	192	.615		
Sum	2139.141	200			

5. Discussion and conclusion

Based on the uses and gratifications theory, this research examined the effects of the image strategies of CEOs on their followers' loyalty in the context of microblogging platforms. Four types of CEO image strategies were identified and examined in terms of two dimensions, interactivity and professionalism. Usage orientation was tested as a moderator on the effects of a CEO's image strategy on his or her followers' loyalty. This is the first study, to our knowledge, to test the effects of different CEO image strategies on the loyalty of followers in the microblogging context. We believe that our findings can have implications for other social media platforms.

In examining the loyalty of followers in relation to the four CEO image strategies, we found that Chinese users are fondest of Expert and Textbook CEOs, that is, CEOs who post messages with highly professional content. Meanwhile, the users were least fond of Daybook CEOs, who were rated low in terms of both interactivity and professionalism. Although social media is well known as a superior means for social interaction, the Friend image strategy was not the best approach for CEOs to retain loyal followers. This result is similar to those of prior research. Xu et al. (2012) found that users of social networks are not solely motivated by fun, while Hughes et al. (2012) showed that people use Facebook mainly for socializing and Twitter mainly for information sharing. Ehrlich and Shami (2010) found that the main purposes of microblogging were to provide information or engage in conversations.

Usage orientation has a significant influence on the effectiveness of image strategies. A goal orientation increases the effect of a highly professional image strategy on followers' loyalty. This finding can be explained on two points. First, goal-oriented microblog users are more active in searching for information and knowledge related to products or technology. Presumably, they pay more attention to CEOs who are good sources of in-depth information and knowledge that may not be obtained from regular sources like a company's website and advertisements. Second, due to the transparency to the public, CEOs are generally expected to be honest and to share accurate information on microblogging platforms.

5.1. Marketing implications

By investing time and energy on microblogging, corporate leaders can build their personal brand and listen to their customers. To improve the return on their investment, they need to gain a significant number of followers. They can do so by meeting the demands of the audience in order to draw their attentions and then gain their trust and loyalty.

The findings of this study can help CEOs develop practical strategies and tactics to enhance their followers' trust and gain or maintain their loyalty. The findings show that users follow CEOs' microblogs mainly to learn rather than to have fun or make friends.

Table 3
Statistics of image strategy and usage orientation.

Orientation	Image	Mean	Standard error	N of sample	Paired *t*-test
Goal-oriented vs. social-oriented	Expert	3.735/2.811	.780/.675	41/38	.000
	Textbook	3.736/2.981	.506/.741	20/15	.000
	Friend	2.905/2.922	.829/.765	21/22	.021
	Daybook	2.880/2.867	.999/.890	29/14	.001

Therefore, we suggest that CEOs who want to build their personal images on microblogging platforms should focus on being professional more important than being interactive. However, there may be a threshold at which the level of social interaction is attractive to users. By taking advantage of the convenient interactions with followers on microblogging platforms, CEOs could narrow the psychological distance that usually exists between them and customers, enhance their reputation, and better present themselves. However, CEOs should be careful to what type of information they share with their followers. The disclosure of some sensitive information might result in lawsuits, leaking trade secrets, or legal actions being taking by government agencies.

In order to better present themselves, CEOs should have a clear sense of who their actual audiences are. followers might be made up of internal and external stakeholders (e.g., customers, shareholders, competitors, investors) with different purposes of following a CEO's microblog. CEOs may take advantages from available analytic tolls and content analysis to gain insight into the construct and interests of their followers.

5.2. Limitations and suggestions for future research

Similar to most pioneering research in a new field, the present one has some limitations, in theory and methodology. Only four image strategies were classified and examined in terms of two aspects in a theoretical setting. There is possibility that other image strategies of CEOs in microblogs may have been overlooked. In the survey, we let the respondents name the CEOs they have followed. This self-reporting method may have introduced bias to the measure of loyalty because the CEOs who were recalled by the respondents without hints were usually the ones who have made the deepest impression on the respondents. To minimize bias in the measures, we suggest that field studies be carried out in the future.

Future studies should consider using content analysis techniques in a large scale to extract real data from well-known microblogging services. The number of followers might be a misleading indicator of loyalty since data shows that a large portion of them are not active. Thus, subsequent studies should consider using the rate of forwarding (e.g., retweets on Twitter) for CEOs' message posts as an indicator of follower loyalty and CEO popularity. Our study was conducted only in China, comparative studies in other countries could shed light on specific cultural differences that might exist. Finally, further studies should explore other strategies to provide better guidance to CEOs' image building in social media space.

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